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Proposed programme budget for 2027

Programme planning

Proposed programme budget for 2027

Part IV

International cooperation for development

Section 13

International Trade Centre

Subprogramme 6 of programme 10

Trade and development

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* The present document (A/81/6 (Sect. 13)/Part A), consisting of the programme plan and programme performance information (part II; see General Assembly resolution [77/267](#), para. 10), will be replaced by a document containing parts A and B (A/81/6 (Sect. 13)) once part B is issued.

** [A/81/50](#).

*** In keeping with paragraph 10 of General Assembly resolution [77/267](#), the part consisting of the programme plan and programme performance information (part II) is submitted through the Committee for Programme and Coordination for the consideration of the Assembly.



A. Proposed programme plan for 2027 and programme performance in 2025

Overall orientation

Mandates and background

- 13.1 The International Trade Centre (ITC) is responsible for the business aspects of trade development, as the joint technical cooperation agency of the United Nations and the World Trade Organization (WTO). The mandate derives from the priorities established by the contracting parties to the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) on 19 March 1964 and the General Assembly on 12 December 1967 (Assembly resolution [2297 \(XXII\)](#)). Since 1 January 1968, ITC has operated under the joint auspices of GATT/WTO and the United Nations. In its resolution [1819 \(LV\)](#) of 9 August 1973, the Economic and Social Council reaffirmed the Centre's mandate as the focal point for technical assistance and cooperation activities for trade promotion within the United Nations system of assistance for developing countries.
- 13.2 In the context of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, Member States explicitly recognized trade as a key engine for sustainable and inclusive economic growth and poverty eradication, specifically through target 8.a of the Sustainable Development Goals, to increase Aid for Trade support, and targets 17.10 and 17.11 of the Goals, for an open, rules-based, transparent and fair-trading system and a significant increase in exports from developing countries. In the Pact for the Future, Member States reiterated their commitment to a rules-based, non-discriminatory, open, fair, inclusive, equitable and transparent multilateral trading system and emphasized the promotion of export-led growth in developing countries, in line with WTO commitments. In the Sevilla Commitment, Member States pledged to support the role of ITC in enhancing the competitiveness and market access of micro-, small and medium-sized enterprises through technical assistance and capacity-building for value addition, regional integration and economic diversification.

Programme of work

Subprogramme 6

Operational aspects of trade promotion and export development

Objective

- 13.3 The objective, to which ITC contributes, is to enhance inclusive and sustainable growth and development through trade and international business development for micro-, small and medium-sized enterprises in developing countries, especially the least developed countries, and countries with economies in transition, through increased business capacities of those enterprises to trade and through a conducive business environment and strengthened institutional ecosystems for those enterprises.

Strategy and external factors for 2027

- 13.4 To contribute to the objective, ITC will provide advisory services, training and awareness-building support to enterprises, business support institutions and government agencies in areas that are key to the international competitiveness of small and medium-sized enterprises, which include microenterprises. In particular, ITC will:
- (a) Build enterprise-level capacities for trade competitiveness in areas such as market analysis, value addition, quality management, e-commerce, marketing, access to finance and investment, climate resilience and environmental risk mitigation;

- (b) Provide small and medium-sized enterprises with market knowledge and new market linkage opportunities, including through initiatives related to digital and sustainable trade and value chain development in targeted sectors;
- (c) Enable business transactions and investment for small and medium-sized enterprises, with a focus on integration into local, regional, South-South and global value chains, and working with women-led businesses, youth entrepreneurs, refugees, and artisan and farmer communities, including through the ITC SheTrades initiative, the Ye! (“young entrepreneurs”) community and the refugees and trade initiative;
- (d) Strengthen the governance, performance, advocacy capacities, quality and scope of services of business support institutions and ecosystems, including trade and investment promotion agencies, chambers of commerce, sectoral organizations, youth and women’s business associations, cooperatives, incubators and technical and vocational training providers;
- (e) Aid policymakers in supporting and advocating for small and medium-sized enterprises, leading public-private dialogues and engaging in consensus-building and decision-making processes that foster private sector competitiveness and internationalization, including through the promotion of the benefits of a universal, rules-based, open, predictable, inclusive, non-discriminatory and equitable multilateral trading system under WTO;
- (f) Scale up its globally accessible trade and market intelligence tools, including databases, which address critical information and knowledge gaps;
- (g) In line with the ITC country engagement strategy, strengthen its small business development and trade advocacy, partnerships and programmatic planning through an enhanced regional and national presence.

13.5 The above-mentioned work is expected to result in:

- (a) Increased resilience of small and medium-sized enterprises to external shocks, enhanced competitiveness and greater integration into regional and international value chains that generate business transactions, investments, sustainable jobs and higher incomes, especially for women, youth and persons in vulnerable situations;
- (b) Improved effectiveness and tailoring of services provided by business support institutions to small and medium-sized enterprises, including through enhanced management and operations of these institutions;
- (c) Better-informed government decision makers with regard to the range of options and related impacts of new or improved inclusive trade-related policies, strategies and regulatory frameworks that contribute to an enabling environment for small and medium-sized enterprises to participate in international trade;
- (d) Increased awareness among policymakers, business support organizations, and businesses related to trade opportunities and challenges for small and medium-sized enterprises, market access conditions, and sustainable business practices.

13.6 With regard to the external factors, the overall plan for 2027 is based on the following planning assumptions:

- (a) Extrabudgetary resources will remain stable;
- (b) Political, economic and social conditions in programming countries will remain conducive to development interventions;
- (c) International trade and investment conditions do not deteriorate significantly compared with 2026.

13.7 With regard to cooperation with other entities at the global, regional, national and local levels, ITC will maintain and develop partnerships with the private sector, civil society, academia, and trade and development organizations to support small and medium-sized enterprises in advancing the implementation of the 2030 Agenda, as well as the Pact for the Future and its Global Digital Compact

and Declaration on Future Generations. ITC will focus on partnerships that contribute to the ITC Global Small and Medium-sized Enterprises Ministerial Meeting; to the development of key value chains in support of the African Continental Free Trade Area; and to initiatives, especially for the least developed countries, small island developing States and landlocked developing countries. ITC will also focus on partnerships that support key outcomes in areas such as digital trade, trade and investment facilitation, women and trade, and access to finance.

- 13.8 With regard to inter-agency coordination and liaison, ITC will continue to coordinate with United Nations entities, including through its participation in the United Nations Sustainable Development Group and United Nations regional and country teams. ITC will collaborate with the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, WTO and other entities and initiatives, such as the World Intellectual Property Organization, the International Telecommunication Union, the International Labour Organization, the International Organization for Migration and the Office of the High Representative for the Least Developed Countries, Landlocked Developing Countries and Small Island Developing States.
- 13.9 ITC integrates a gender perspective in its operational activities, deliverables and results, as appropriate. ITC will promote gender equality and women's empowerment by providing support, upon request, to improve women's access to finance, strengthen business support organizations' services, including through its network of SheTrades hubs; amplify the voice of women's organizations in the African Continental Free Trade Area; and serve more women in vulnerable situations.
- 13.10 In line with the United Nations Disability Inclusion Strategy, ITC will advance the use of a disability inclusion marker in its programming portfolio and will aim to implement more initiatives that foster the inclusion of persons with disabilities in trade.

Adjustments arising from the UN80 Initiative

- 13.11 The proposed programme plan for 2027 reflects changes arising from the UN80 Initiative. In particular, the table of deliverables reflects updated planned deliverables for 2026 as a result of the changes reflected in the approved programme budget for 2026. For example, the *SME Competitiveness Outlook* will be published biennially, and publications, including the annual report, will increasingly be moved online. Certain information materials, such as the *International Trade Forum* magazine, will have a lower publication frequency.
- 13.12 ITC will be guided by any future decisions taken in the context of the UN80 Initiative, in accordance with the applicable rules and procedures, including decisions, resolutions and established practice of the competent intergovernmental organs.

Evaluation activities

- 13.13 The following evaluations conducted by ITC and completed in 2025 have guided the proposed programme plan for 2027:
 - (a) 2025 annual evaluation synthesis report (meta-evaluation of 2024 evaluation findings);
 - (b) Thematic evaluation of the export quality management offering of ITC;
 - (c) Final evaluation of the Netherlands Trust Fund (NTF) Phase V programme;
 - (d) Country-level project evaluations in the Gambia and Uganda.
- 13.14 In response to the results of the evaluations referenced above, ITC will leverage evidence and lessons learned to guide the implementation of the strategic plan for the period 2026–2030. Insights from the thematic evaluation will strengthen support for quality infrastructure and compliance services, while findings from the final evaluation of the NTF Phase V programme will inform approaches to building inclusive value chains and digital trade ecosystems through reinforced public-private partnerships, as outlined under result 3. Lessons from the project evaluation in the Gambia will shape

trade initiatives addressing migration drivers, while those from Uganda will enhance youth entrepreneurship interventions, focusing on digital skills and access to finance.

13.15 The following evaluations are planned for 2027:

- (a) The 2027 annual evaluation synthesis report;
- (b) One strategic evaluation of an ITC corporate topic or thematic area;
- (c) One strategic evaluation of an ITC large, pilot or innovative project;
- (d) One project-level evaluation.

Programme performance in 2025

Strengthened innovation, business and job opportunities in Africa and Latin America for youth start-ups and entrepreneurs

13.16 As global economies face rapid transformation due to digitalization, climate change and rising youth unemployment, fostering entrepreneurship among young people is critical for inclusive economic growth and sustainable job creation. ITC partnered with a development cooperation organization to jointly deliver the Youth Startup Academy. Anchored in co-creation, the Academy model combined the expertise of local business support organizations with the knowledge tools of ITC to incubate start-up businesses. Strong involvement of country-based institutions has set solid foundations for local ownership and sustainability. Following a successful roll-out in Uganda, the Academy was replicated in Colombia, adapted to its socioeconomic environment and mainly aimed at young people in less developed regions. Through ITC capacity-building support and tailored advisory solutions, young entrepreneurs seized new business opportunities with international investors and trade partners.

Table 13.1

Performance measure

2023 (actual)	2024 (actual)	2025 (actual)
–	In Uganda, over 1,100 youth entrepreneurs in sectors such as financial technology, healthcare technology, agricultural technology and energy received Youth Startup Academy support. The participating start-ups created over 3,700 new jobs and generated \$7 million in sales and nearly \$3 million in investment	In Colombia, 450 small and medium-sized enterprises in sectors such as digital health, agricultural technology, climate adaptation and science-based entrepreneurship improved their competitiveness through the Youth Startup Academy programmes. These entrepreneurs attracted over \$5.8 million in investments and created over 350 jobs

Planned results for 2027

Result 1: strengthened services provided by local business support organizations to small businesses to capitalize on the African Continental Free Trade Area

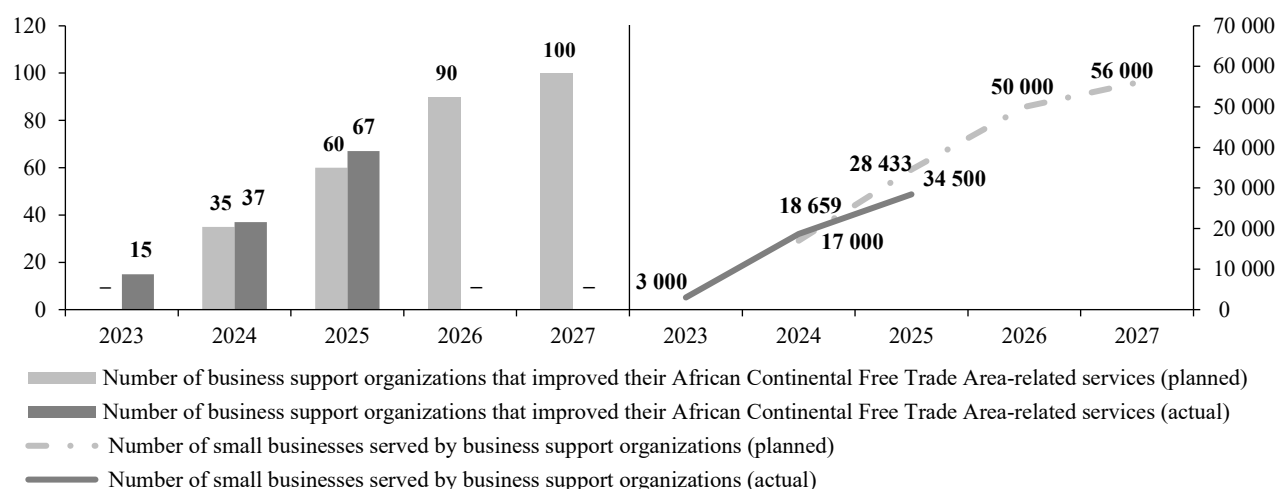
Programme performance in 2025 and target for 2027

13.17 The programme's work contributed to 67 business support organizations that improved their African Continental Free Trade Area-related services and 28,433 small businesses served by those organizations, which exceeded the target of 60 business support organizations and did not meet the planned target of 34,500 small businesses. The target was not met because of the smaller sizes and membership counts of some contributing organizations as compared with the expected average.

13.18 Progress towards the objective and the target for 2027 are presented in the performance measure below (see figure 13.I).

Figure 13.I

Performance measure: number of business support organizations that improved their African Continental Free Trade Area-related services and number of small businesses served by those business support organizations (cumulative)



Result 2: transition of textile and clothing small and medium-sized enterprises in Africa and the Asia-Pacific region to sustainable operations

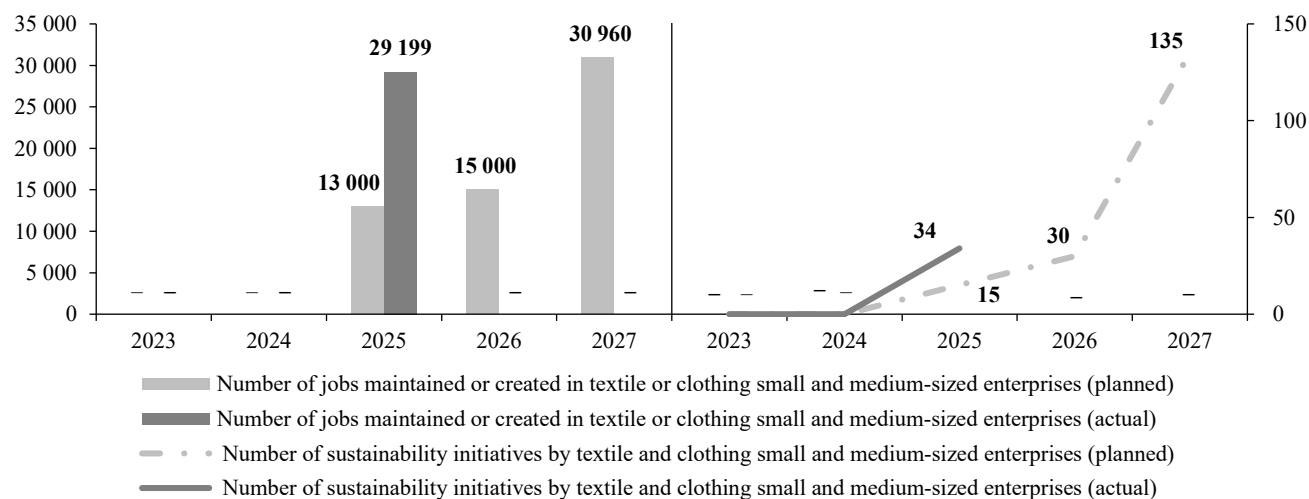
Programme performance in 2025 and target for 2027

13.19 The programme's work contributed to 29,199 jobs maintained or created in textile or clothing small and medium-sized enterprises and in 34 sustainability initiatives by those enterprises, which exceeded the planned target of 13,000 jobs maintained or created and 15 sustainability initiatives.

13.20 Progress towards the objective and the target for 2027 are presented in the performance measure below (see figure 13.II).

Figure 13.II

Performance measure: number of jobs and sustainability initiatives in textile and clothing small and medium-sized enterprises in Africa and the Asia-Pacific region (cumulative)



Result 3: strengthened export competitiveness of small and medium-sized enterprises from Eastern Europe and Central Asia

Proposed programme plan for 2027

- 13.21 In Eastern Europe and Central Asia, policymakers have recognized the need for strong value chains to support export diversification and regional integration. Small and medium-sized enterprises have actively pursued operational improvements to add value and access higher-value export markets. ITC has supported strategic value chain development across several countries, assisting small and medium-sized enterprises in key agribusiness sectors, including dried fruits, nuts, medicinal herbs and vegetable oils, and in the textiles and clothing sector.

Lessons learned and planned change

- 13.22 The lesson for ITC, based on its experience in Central Asia, was that value chain development is most effective when small and medium-sized enterprises are supported through a systemic sectoral approach, with the involvement of business ecosystem actors, including policymakers and business support organizations. In applying the lesson, ITC will scale up and replicate this approach, including in sectors such as textiles and clothing and agribusiness, enabling more small and medium-sized enterprises to become more competitive and better integrated in value chains. ITC will also leverage partnerships with business ecosystem actors for more sustainable results.
- 13.23 Expected progress towards the objective is presented in the performance measure below (see table 13.2).

Table 13.2

Performance measure

2023 (actual)	2024 (actual)	2025 (actual)	2026 (planned)	2027 (planned)
Textile and clothing small and medium-sized enterprises in Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan increased their export value by \$8 million	Armenian, Tajik and Uzbek small and medium-sized enterprises in the agribusiness sector signed contracts worth over \$24 million	Policymakers developed a 2026–2028 road map for the development of exports of Kazakh oil and fat products	80 small and medium-sized enterprises in Eastern European and Central Asian countries enhance their competitiveness	50 small and medium-sized enterprises in Eastern European and Central Asian countries transact international business

Legislative mandates

- 13.24 The list below, which was reviewed in the preparation of the proposed programme budget, provides all mandates entrusted to ITC.

General Assembly resolutions

2297 (XXII)	International Trade Centre	77/330	Cooperation between the United Nations and the Economic Cooperation Organization
69/313	Addis Ababa Action Agenda of the Third International Conference on Financing for Development (Addis Ababa Action Agenda)	78/317	The Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for Small Island Developing States: A Renewed Declaration for Resilient Prosperity
70/1	Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development	79/1	The Pact for the Future
71/279	Micro-, Small and Medium-sized Enterprises Day	79/201	Entrepreneurship for sustainable development
76/258	Doha Programme of Action for the Least Developed Countries	79/215	Towards a New International Economic Order
		79/216	Role of the United Nations in promoting development in the context of globalization and interdependence

Part IV		International cooperation for development	
79/220	Promotion of sustainable and resilient tourism, including ecotourism, for poverty eradication and environmental protection	80/138	Protection of global climate for present and future generations of humankind
79/222	Industrial development cooperation	80/147	Science, technology and innovation for sustainable development
79/223	Women in development	80/149	Development cooperation with middle-income countries
79/226	Quadrennial comprehensive policy review of operational activities for development of the United Nations system	80/150	Follow-up to the Fifth United Nations Conference on the Least Developed Countries
79/228	Towards global partnerships: a principle-based approach to enhanced cooperation between the United Nations and all relevant partners	80/151	Follow-up to the Third United Nations Conference on Landlocked Developing Countries
79/233	Programme of Action for Landlocked Developing Countries for the Decade 2024–2034	80/153	Implementation of the Third United Nations Decade for the Eradication of Poverty (2018–2027)
79/323	Sevilla Commitment	80/155	Operational activities for development of the United Nations system
80/118	Information and communications technologies for sustainable development	80/156	South-South cooperation
80/121	International trade and development	80/180	Policies and programmes involving youth
80/129	Follow-up to and implementation of the outcomes of the International Conferences on Financing for Development	80/182	Cooperatives in social development
		80/184	Improvement of the situation of women and girls in rural areas
80/135	Promoting sustainable consumption and production patterns for the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, building on Agenda 21	80/186	Follow-up to the Fourth World Conference on Women and full implementation of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action and the outcome of the twenty-third special session of the General Assembly
80/136	Follow-up to and implementation of the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for Small Island Developing States: A Renewed Declaration for Resilient Prosperity		
<i>Economic and Social Council resolutions</i>			
1819 (LV)	United Nations export promotion programmes	2025/4	Mainstreaming a gender perspective into all policies and programmes in the United Nations system
<i>World Trade Organization ministerial declarations, decisions and other ministerial outcome documents</i>			
WT/MIN(01)/DEC/1	Doha Ministerial Declaration	WT/MIN(17)/58	Joint Ministerial statement: Declaration on the Establishment of a WTO Informal Work Programme for Micro, Small and Medium-sized Enterprises
WT/MIN(05)/DEC	Doha Work Programme: Ministerial Declaration		
WT/MIN(13)/DEC	Bali Ministerial Declaration	WT/MIN(17)/59	Joint Ministerial Statement on Investment Facilitation for Development
WT/MIN(15)/DEC	Nairobi Ministerial Declaration	WT/MIN(17)/60	Joint statement on Electronic Commerce
		WT/MIN(24)/DEC	Abu Dhabi Ministerial Declaration

Deliverables

13.25 Table 13.3 lists all deliverables of ITC.

Table 13.3
Deliverables for the period 2025–2027, by category and subcategory

<i>Category and subcategory</i>	<i>2025 planned</i>	<i>2025 actual</i>	<i>2026 planned</i>	<i>2027 planned</i>
A. Facilitation of the intergovernmental process and expert bodies				
Parliamentary documentation (number of documents)	4	4	4	4
1. Reports to the Joint Advisory Group on the International Trade Centre and the Consultative Committee of the ITC trust fund	3	3	3	3
2. Annual report on the activities of ITC to the Joint Advisory Group on the International Trade Centre and the Consultative Committee of the ITC trust fund	1	1	1	1
Substantive services for meetings (number of three-hour meetings)	8	8	8	8
Meetings of:				
3. The Joint Advisory Group on the International Trade Centre and formal meetings of the Consultative Committee of the ITC trust fund	4	4	4	4
4. The Advisory Committee on Administrative and Budgetary Questions	1	1	1	1
5. The Fifth Committee	1	1	1	1
6. The Committee for Programme and Coordination	1	1	1	1
7. The WTO Committee on Budget, Finance and Administration	1	1	1	1
B. Generation and transfer of knowledge				
Field and technical cooperation projects (number of projects)	145	146	145	145
8. On trade-related technical assistance	145	146	145	145
Seminars, workshops and training events (number of days)	5 000	3 867	5 000	4 500
9. Training events on trade intelligence, policy and strategy	1 200	842	1 200	1 000
10. Training events on business support institutions and ecosystems	800	767	800	800
11. Training events on value chains and sustainability	3 000	2 258	3 000	2 700
Technical materials (number of materials)	30	31	28	20
12. <i>SME Competitiveness Outlook</i> flagship report	1	1	–	1
13. Books on trade-related subjects	4	5	4	4
14. Papers on trade-related subjects, such as inclusive and sustainable trade, trade and market intelligence, and the competitiveness of small and medium-sized enterprises (including women- or youth-led enterprises)	25	25 24 [26] ^a		15

C. Substantive deliverables

Consultation, advice and advocacy: advice to policymakers, trade support institutions and enterprises to address the international competitiveness challenges for small and medium-sized enterprises in developing countries and countries with economies in transition, to facilitate public-private dialogue on improvements to the business environment and to ensure that trade supports inclusive and sustainable development; advisory services to disadvantaged groups among small and medium-sized enterprises, such as women- and youth-owned enterprises, on improving their productive capacity and market access; advisory and advocacy services for policymakers and business support institutions on how to consider the needs of small and medium-sized enterprises and disadvantaged groups in their service offer; and advocacy that allows for the systematic inclusion of such enterprises and disadvantaged groups in policy and strategy processes.

Databases and substantive digital materials: databases and other online tools to make global trade more transparent and facilitate market access and business and policy decisions. Databases cover trade flows, tariffs and non-tariff measures, export potential, procurement opportunities, rules of origin, private standards and knowledge on sustainable trade and youth and women entrepreneurship. They include the SheTrades website; “SheTrades Outlook”; the ITC SME Trade Academy; the Ye! community and platform; the Benchmarking for Trade platform; the Quality for Trade platform; the ecomConnect platforms; the suite of regional integrated solutions (African Trade Observatory, West African Competitiveness Observatory, Euromed Trade Helpdesk and Eastern Partnership Trade Helpdesk) and the suite of market analysis tools (Trade Map, Market Access Map, Rules of Origin Facilitator, Export Potential Map, Investment Map, Procurement Map and Global Trade Helpdesk); the Strategies Implementation Management Tool; the Sustainability Map, the Standards Map, and the ePing platform.

Category and subcategory	2025 planned	2025 actual	2026 planned	2027 planned
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D. Communication deliverables

Outreach programmes, special events and information materials: special events, including the Global Small and Medium-sized Enterprises Ministerial Meeting, the Trade for Sustainable Development Forum, and Micro-, Small and Medium-sized Enterprises Day; the *Trade Forum* digital magazine; newsletters on trade-related subjects; and information materials and outreach, including on export strategy, trade support networks and capacities, entrepreneurship, skills and export development opportunities, world trade trends, the multilateral trading system, regional integration, technical regulations and standards for export, and trade and the Sustainable Development Goals.

Digital platforms and multimedia content: ITC website and social media accounts, engaging small and medium-sized enterprises, policymakers, business support organizations and the wider trade and development community.

Library services: on-demand services for ITC clients related to trade information.

^a Reflects updated planned deliverables for 2026. Value in square brackets represents the number of planned deliverables reflected in [A/80/6 \(Sect. 13\)](#).